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Education

Columbia University Ph.D. Candidate in Economics (BusEc track)	2020 - 2026
Bocconi University M.S. in Economics and Social Sciences, <i>110/110 Cum Laude</i>	2020
Bocconi University B.S. in International Economics and Finance, <i>110/110 Cum Laude</i>	2017

Research Interests

Political Economy, Media Economics, Organizational Economics

Job Market Paper

An Image is Worth 1000 Words? Partisanship and Attention in Videos

Abstract: Political news today is increasingly consumed in attention-scarce, video-based environments. Yet existing research on media partisanship remains text-centric and implicitly assumes long-form, attentive processing. This paper studies how partisanship operates in video news through the transmission of multi-modal signals: images and text. I develop a multimodal measure of video partisanship to quantify partisan content in video news and decompose the contribution of each modality. I show that the informational strength of each modality depends on attention: images convey partisanship rapidly through affective cues, while text operates through substantive information that requires sustained exposure to accumulate. A survey experiment using real news footage shows how these properties shape viewers' responses to political videos. Partisan images elicit immediate emotional responses even under brief exposure, whereas partisan text shifts policy attitudes only with sustained exposure. Overall, the results show how low-attention video environments reshape persuasion, by filtering out substantive textual information, and relying mostly on the emotional effect of visual signals. Efforts to improve media quality must account for the asymmetric roles of visual and textual content.

Working Papers

The Mechanistic Fixed-Effects Topic Model: Recovering Corporate Culture from Employee Reviews

with [Dan Biderman](#), [David Blei](#), [Wei Cai](#), [Amir Feder](#) and [Andrea Prat](#)

Abstract: Social scientists use topic models to compare documents produced by different authors and in different contexts, even though the same broad topic may be expressed differently across environments. Existing methods usually control for this variation ex post and cannot separate common themes from environment-specific language. Their reliance on word counts also misses concepts conveyed through phrases, context, and tone. We introduce the mechanistic Fixed Effects Topic Model (mFETM), which embeds fixed effects in

the generative process and replaces word counts with interpretable concepts extracted from a large language model using sparse autoencoders (SAEs). Applied to a large corpus of Glassdoor reviews, mFETM recovers topics that are more stable across observed environments without sacrificing fit. At the firm level, it recovers a broader, more interpretable range of workplace dimensions associated with top employers. A conventional model mixes these dimensions with environment-specific topics, such as technology strategy. The result is a narrower account of what distinguishes top employers and a substantially larger loss of fit when environment-associated topics are removed. Finally, the SAE representation lets us generate counterfactual reviews by steering along estimated fixed-effect directions, holding the topic fixed while changing its environment.

With or Without Conditions? Equity-Efficiency Tradeoffs in Municipal Transfers in Brazil with *Luigi Caloi*

Abstract: To improve service delivery, central governments can tie intergovernmental transfers to local policy performance. While performance-based transfers incentivize local governments and generate efficiency gains, they also shift transfers from low- to high-capacity governments, creating welfare-reducing inequities. We study this equity-efficiency trade-off using a bundle of transfer reforms to Brazilian municipalities. When two states tied transfers to relative educational performance, student test scores rose substantially: moving from the 25th to the 75th percentile of per capita conditional transfers increased scores by 0.16 standard deviations. However, the reform also widened funding disparities across municipalities, which translated into disparities in municipal expenditures in multiple sectors. In contrast, contemporaneous reforms to unconditional transfers had negligible effects on student outcomes. We use a simple model of optimal transfers to interpret these findings. Our results suggest that the introduction of performance based transfers delivered large efficiency gains, limited welfare losses from inequities, and was welfare-enhancing. We find minimal evidence of multitasking distortions or score manipulation. Instead, we document improvements in the quality of education inputs and find suggestive evidence of reduced corruption.

Awards, Fellowships, and Grants

CPE Graduate Student Grant Opportunity, <i>Columbia Center for Political Economy</i>	2024
CELSS Seed Grant, <i>Columbia Experimental Laboratory in the Social Sciences</i>	2024
J-PAL's Jobs and Opportunity Initiative Brazil (with Luigi Caloi), <i>J-PAL</i>	2023
Wueller Fellowship for Best Teaching Fellow (Runner-up), <i>Columbia University</i>	2022
Dean's Fellowship, <i>Columbia University</i>	2020 – Present

Seminars & Conferences

IOG-BFI Spring Conference, Economics of Media Bias Workshop,	2026
Bocconi AI and Society Conference, CEPR Media Workshop	
AI+Economics Workshop Zurich	2025

Other Research Experience

Research Assistant to Prof. Andrea Prat and Andrey Simonov, <i>Columbia Business School</i>	2021–2024
Research Assistant to Prof. Cailin Slattery, <i>Columbia Business School</i>	2021–2022
Research Assistant to Prof. Thomas Le Barbanchon, Bocconi University	2019–2020
Research Assistant to Prof. Marco Ottaviani, Bocconi University	2019–2020

Teaching Experience

Main Instructor in Math Camp (Economics MA)	2022 – 2024
Guest Lecturer in Political Economy (PhD), Prof. Andrea Prat	2022 – 2024
TA in Industrial Organization (MA), Prof. Ildikó Magyari	2024
TA in Game Theory and Business (MBA), Prof. Andrea Prat	2022 – 2024

TA in Corporate Finance (UG), Prof. Tri Vi Dang	2023
TA in Math Methods for Economists (MA), Prof. Isaac Bjorke	2022

Academic Service

Referee: *Economica*, *Economic Journal*

Bio

Citizenship: Italian
Gender: Male

References

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